

mac and cheese, but the best way to get your money's worth at a buffet is to eat as fresh as possible. Melons, berries, broccoli, and avocados are yummy ways to eat healthy and increase the value of your buffet. Encourage kids to eat one full plate of fresh stuff before they even head toward the french fries and fried shrimp. They will get loads of nutrients, and you can feel good knowing the extra cost gave them more than any fast-food kid's meal could really provide.

5. Take your time

Buffets are not a dine-and-dash type of atmosphere. If you are squeezing in your meal between two other pressing matters, pick another day to buffet. We like to take a weekday with nothing else to do, go early, and stay late. We snack, talk, and enjoy each other's company while sampling all kinds of new foods. If we do it right, we can have a lunch/dinner combo that knocks out two meals in one. We try to leaving by 4:30, so as not to get charged for dinner, too! We think of it as the same concept as a brunch, but with the two later meals combined. And if kids get hungry at home later, we snack on yogurt and granola, or another kind of light breakfast food before retiring for the evening.

6. Know what's safe

Even the most talked-about buffets can be a health risk. Be aware of your surroundings, and watch for common food-safety issues that may make you sick later. Aim for foods that are fairly popular, get switched out often, and appear fresh. If anything doesn't look right, please don't eat it! And let a manager know of your findings. Raw fishes should be approached with caution, and any salad made with mayonnaise should be eyed carefully. (It's a bad idea to go for that tuna salad with the orangish-looking crust on top.)

7. Explore your options

There are many types of buffets that appeal to our family. We like Chinese, American, and Italian the best. In areas that offer more diverse options, I'm sure there are many more kinds to choose from. Encourage your family to try new things while at the buffet. After all, if they don't like their first choice, they can just try another dish—and you won't be out any more money.

8. Be courteous

While buffets are great for saving money, they also seem to attract